05 – Prompt basics

AI Training for Beginners

Self-study training: use AI/LLMs safely in everyday life

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https://github.com/mgunthner/AI-Training

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05 – Prompt basics

Definition: A **prompt** is your input to the AI. A good prompt says clearly what you want, what you need it for and what the result should look like.

> **Remember:** Whatever you don’t say, the AI will guess. And it doesn’t always guess right.

Key points

- **Building blocks:** *Goal* (what do you need it for?), *context* (background), *task* (exactly what?), *format* (length, list, table), *restrictions* (what should be avoided?) and *audience* (who is it for?). You don’t always need all six.
- **Template (rule of thumb):** Role/goal → context → task → format → limits.
- **Concrete instead of vague:** “3 paragraphs, factual, for retirees” instead of “write something nice”.
- **One task per prompt** or numbered steps. If you demand five things at once, you often get five half-finished results.
- **Allow follow-up questions:** “Ask me follow-up questions before you start.” That way you find out what the AI is missing.
- **Iterate:** The first answer is a draft. Say what’s missing or bothers you, and have it improved.

Example (before/after)

Before (too vague):

```
Write something nice for the neighbors.
```

After:

```
I want to invite the neighbors in my building to a summer party in
↪  the courtyard.
Write an invitation for the notice board in the stairwell.
Audience: young and old. Tone: warm. Length: at most 80 words.
Use placeholders for date and time.
Ask me follow-up questions first if anything is missing.
```

Do / Don’t

Do	Don’t
State goal, format and audience	“Write something nice” and hope for luck
Ask one task per prompt	Pack five assignments into one sentence
Follow up: “Shorter, and without jargon”	Give up on the first result or accept everything
Allow follow-up questions	Let the AI invent missing details

Safety note

Give only as much background as necessary. Replace real names, addresses and numbers with placeholders (see topic 04). A good prompt makes the answer better, but not automatically correct. Check it (topic 08).

Mini checklist

- ☐ I state goal and task.
- ☐ I say what the result should look like (format, length, tone).
- ☐ I ask one task per prompt.
- ☐ I follow up on the first answer instead of accepting it.

Exercise (5 min.)

Take a vague everyday prompt, e.g. “Help me move house.” Improve it in three rounds: 1. Add goal and task. 2. Add format, audience and limits. 3. Read the answer and tell the AI what bothers you.

Compare rounds 1 and 3. Save the best prompt in your prompt library.

Next

- Extra exercises: `02_extra_exercises/05_extra_exercises`
- Test: Quick test: quick start, Test B (Good results)
- Related: 04 Data privacy, 06 Prompt techniques, 07 Prior knowledge & context, 08 Hallucinations

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